

3.2 Unit 2 PSYB2 Social Psychology, Cognitive Psychology and Individual Differences

Students should have experience of designing and conducting informal classroom research using a variety of methods. They will be expected to analyse data collected in investigations and draw conclusions based on research findings. They will be required to draw on

these experiences to answer questions in the examination for this unit.

In order to answer questions in this Unit, candidates must have studied Experimental Methods in Unit 1 (3.1.4).

Social Psychology

Topics

3.2.1 Social Influence

3.2.2 Social Cognition

Aims

- To provide an introduction to theoretical and methodological approaches in social psychology.
 - To demonstrate ways in which social psychology may be applied to contemporary social and cultural issues.
 - To enable students to develop critical and evaluative skills in relation to theory and empirical studies in social psychology.
 - To develop an appreciation of how science works in social psychology.
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3.2.1 Social Influence

Social facilitation, dominant responses, causes of arousal: evaluation apprehension and distraction. Effects of arousal on task performance.

Types of conformity, including internalisation and compliance.

Explanations for conformity, including informational social influence and normative social influence.

Factors affecting conformity, including those investigated by Asch.

Explanations of obedience.

Situational factors: conditions affecting obedience to authority as investigated by Milgram.

Dispositional explanation: the Authoritarian Personality.

Explanations of defiance of authority.

Ethical and methodological issues in studying social influence.

3.2.2 Social Cognition

Factors affecting impression formation, including social schemas, primacy and recency effects, central traits and stereotyping.

Concept of attribution: dispositional and situational attributions; attributional biases, including the fundamental attribution error, the actor-observer effect and the self-serving bias.

The structure and function of attitudes: cognitive affective and behavioural components; adaptive, knowledge and ego-expressive functions.

Explanations of prejudice, including competition for resources, social identity theory and the Authoritarian Personality.

Cognitive Psychology

Topics

Aims

3.2.3 Remembering and forgetting

3.2.4 Perceptual Processes

- To introduce students to major areas of study in cognitive psychology.
- To give students an understanding of methodological approaches in cognitive psychology.
- To develop a critical awareness of theories and research in cognitive psychology.
- To develop an appreciation of how science works in cognitive psychology.

3.2.3 Remembering and Forgetting

Models of memory including the distinguishing features/ components of each of the following:

The Multi-store model (Atkinson and Shiffrin);

Working memory model;

Levels of processing.

Types of long-term memory: episodic; semantic; procedural.

Autobiographical memory.

Explanations of forgetting, including decay, interference, retrieval failure (absence of context and cues), displacement, lack of consolidation and motivated forgetting, including repression.

3.2.4 Perceptual Processes

Perceptual set and the effects of motivation, expectation, emotion and culture on perception.

Perceptual organisation. The Gestalt principles.

Gibson's and Gregory's theories of visual perception.

Depth cues, monocular and binocular. Types of perceptual constancy, including size constancy and shape constancy.

Distortion illusions, including the Muller-Lyer illusion and the Ponzo illusion.

Ambiguous figures, including the Necker Cube and Rubin's vase.

What distortion illusions and ambiguous figures tell us about perception.

Individual Differences

Topics

Aims

3.2.5 Anxiety Disorders

3.2.6 Autism

- To provide an introduction to research into individual differences.
- To develop critical awareness of explanations for anxiety disorders or autism.
- To develop an understanding of the application of psychology in the assessment and treatment of anxiety disorders or autism.
- To develop an appreciation of how science works in research into individual differences.

3.2.5 Anxiety Disorders

Phobias: definition and symptoms. Agoraphobia, social phobias and specific phobias.

Obsessive-compulsive disorder: definition and symptoms. The distinction between obsession and compulsion.

Explanations of phobias and obsessive-compulsive disorder, including biological, behavioural, cognitive and psychodynamic.

Treatments, including systematic desensitisation, flooding, drug therapy, cognitive therapy; psychodynamic therapy.

Evaluation of these treatments.

3.2.6 Autism

Autism: Definition and symptoms, including lack of joint attention.

Autism as a syndrome: the triad of impairments.

An early explanation: cold-parenting.

Biological explanations, including genetics and neurological correlates.

Cognitive explanations, including theory of mind, central coherence deficit and failure of executive functioning.

Studying autism: the Sally-Anne experiment; the 'Smartie tube' test; comic strip stories.

Therapeutic programmes for autism, including behaviour modification, aversion therapy for self-injuring behaviour, language training, including the Lovaas technique, parental involvement.

Evaluation of these programmes.